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Simeon and Anna

Two faithful people in the temple who had waited long, and knew the Saviour when they saw him.

When Mary and Joseph brought the forty-day-old Jesus to the temple, two people were waiting there. Simeon was a righteous and devout man in Jerusalem. The Holy Ghost had shown him he would not die before he saw the Lord's Christ. Led by the Spirit into the temple that day, he took the baby in his arms and blessed God, for he had seen God's salvation. Anna was an elderly prophetess, a widow for most of her long life, who never left the temple but worshipped with fasting and prayer night and day. She came in at that moment, gave thanks, and told everyone who was waiting for redemption. Together they show what patient, hopeful waiting on God looks like.

At a glance

<i>Names</i>	Simeon, "hearing" or "he has heard"; Anna, a form of Hannah, "grace" or "favour"
<i>Simeon</i>	"just and devout, waiting for the consolation of Israel" (Luke 2:25)
<i>Anna</i>	A prophetess, daughter of Phanuel, of the tribe of Asher (Luke 2:36)
<i>When</i>	c. 6–4 BC, forty days after Jesus' birth
<i>Key place</i>	The temple in Jerusalem
<i>Key people</i>	Mary, mother of Jesus; Joseph of Nazareth
<i>Main passages</i>	Luke 2:22–38

"Lord, now lettest thou thy servant depart in peace, according to thy word: For mine eyes have seen thy salvation."

Luke 2:29–30, KJV

The life of Simeon and Anna

Dates are approximate (BC). Luke gives no age for Simeon, and Anna's age can be read two ways.

Anna's youth	● Married, then widowed Anna lives with her husband seven years after her marriage. Then he dies, and she remains a widow for the rest of her long life. <i>Luke 2:36-37</i>
The long years	● Waiting in the temple Anna does not depart from the temple, serving God with fastings and prayers night and day. In Jerusalem, Simeon waits for the consolation of Israel, and the Holy Ghost is upon him. <i>Luke 2:25, 37</i>
Earlier	● Simeon's promise The Holy Ghost reveals to Simeon that he will not see death before he has seen the Lord's Christ, God's promised anointed King. <i>Luke 2:26</i>
c. 6-4 BC <i>Forty days</i>	● Simeon holds the child Led by the Spirit into the temple as Jesus is presented, Simeon takes him in his arms and blesses God. He then blesses the parents and warns Mary of sorrow to come. <i>Luke 2:27-35</i>
c. 6-4 BC <i>That same hour</i>	● Anna gives thanks Anna comes in at that very moment. She gives thanks to the Lord and speaks of the child to all who look for redemption in Jerusalem. <i>Luke 2:38</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Luke 2:37 says Anna was "a widow of about fourscore and four years." This may mean she was 84, or that she had been a widow for 84 years, which would make her over 100.

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- 1 **Waited with hope.** Simeon looked for the consolation of Israel, trusting the promise God had given him. *Luke 2:25*
 - 2 **Followed the Spirit's leading.** Simeon came "by the Spirit" into the temple at the very time Jesus was brought in. *Luke 2:27*
 - 3 **Recognised the Saviour.** He took the baby in his arms and called him God's salvation, "A light to lighten the Gentiles, and the glory of thy people Israel." *Luke 2:28-32*
 - 4 **Spoke a hard truth.** Simeon told Mary the child was set for the fall and rising again of many in Israel, and "a sword shall pierce through thy own soul also." *Luke 2:34-35*
 - 5 **Worshipped without ceasing.** Anna served God with fastings and prayers night and day. *Luke 2:37*
 - 6 **Told others.** Anna gave thanks and spoke of Jesus to all who were looking for redemption. *Luke 2:38*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Simeon or Anna.

Old Testament

Isaiah 40:1	"Comfort ye, comfort ye my people," the hope Simeon awaited
Isaiah 49:6	"A light to the Gentiles," echoed by Simeon
Echo: 1 Samuel 1:9–18	Hannah, whose name Anna shares, prays at God's house
Echo: Genesis 46:30	Jacob content to die once he has seen Joseph

New Testament

Luke 2:22–38	The only account of them
Luke 24:21	Disciples hoped Jesus would "have redeemed Israel"
1 Timothy 5:5	A widow praying "night and day," as Anna did
Tradition	Simeon as a very old man or a priest; Luke says neither

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What had the Holy Ghost promised Simeon (Luke 2:26)?
2. *Understand:* Simeon calls Jesus a light to the Gentiles and the glory of Israel. Why is it important that Jesus came for both?
3. *Apply:* Anna waited and prayed for decades, and Simeon held on to God's promise. What helps you keep hoping in God while you wait?
4. *Apply:* Anna told others about Jesus as soon as she met him. Who is one person you could tell about what God has done for you?